



## RHODOPES BULGARIA

## Patatnik in the Rhodopes

Along the vast green undulations of the Rhodope Mountains, shepherds rely on fearsome Karakachan dogs to guard their flocks against wolves, and farmers use oxen to plow the fields. Rural life here is simple, satisfying, and healthy, and the cuisine reflects this lifestyle, with a series of delicious, wholesome dishes such as *patatnik*, a golden-crusted potato pie.



Straddling Greece and Bulgaria, the thickly forested Rhodopes spread over more than 4,000 square miles (10,000 km<sup>2</sup>), and they are dotted with picturesque villages where life has changed little for centuries. Home to an abundance of wildlife, the mountains are renowned for their stunning limestone gorges, deep caverns, and pristine lakes. Hikers can follow a wealth of well-marked trails linked by simple mountain huts, and skiers fill the snow-covered slopes at Pamporovo, one of Bulgaria's premier ski resorts.

A good base for touring is Smolyan, a town near Pamporovo that's also close to the Smolyan Lakes and the towering Orpheus Rocks. The legendary Orpheus is said to have been born in the Rhodopes, later entering the underworld to search for his wife at the breathtaking gorge of "The Devil's Throat" near Trigrad. In Zlatograd, a bit farther south, there's a chance to see – and stay in – perfectly preserved traditional houses and workshops, now protected as part of an ethnographic complex.

The region has been populated for millennia, but it wasn't until the mid-19th century that potatoes were introduced here. Initially rejected as "devil's apples" by superstitious elders, potatoes eventually proved

successful as they thrived at high altitude in the rich Rhodopean soil. Canny villagers were quick to recognize their potential and, having boiled, baked, roasted, and fried the hardy new vegetable, began to experiment with a potato version of *banitsa*, a traditional Bulgarian pastry. This ultimately evolved into *patatnik*, a subtle blend of grated potato, white cheese, egg, onion, and mint cooked slowly in a pan over a wood stove.

During the economic upheaval that followed the collapse of Socialism in the 1990s, the then prime minister Ivan Kostov famously exhorted Rhodopeans to profit from their potato expertise and "Make patatnik!" Locals took heed and started to promote the dish as a culinary tourist attraction to be eaten in cozy traditional pubs (*mehanas*). Today *patatnik* is firmly established as the region's classic dish, and every *mehana* serves its own version – some add tomatoes and red pepper, while others bake it in an oven rather than cook it on a stove, but all use a few crushed mint leaves to enhance the distinctive *patatnik* flavor. The hour-plus cooking time isn't really a problem, because it's easily spent beside a crackling log fire in a hospitable *mehana*, sampling some freshly baked bread and nursing a fine glass of *rakia*, a spirit distilled from mountain plums.



**Above** The cheesy onion and potato *patatnik* evolved from the *banitsa*, a Bulgarian savory filled pastry

**Right** The village of Shiroka Luka has been declared an Architectural Reserve, with many authentic Rhodopean buildings dating back to the early 19th century

**Below** Away from the cities, up in the mountains, many people still travel simply with a donkey and cart



### Three Days in the Rhodope Mountains

The best way to experience the Rhodopes is to spend weeks walking through them, but if time is short, you can easily experience the highlights on a driving tour.

**DAY ONE** Though blighted by some unappealing Socialist-era buildings, **Smolyan's** mountainous setting is still wondrously dramatic. Visit the **Historical Museum**, then head for the tiny nearby village of **Momchilovtsi**, high in the mountains.

**DAY TWO** Visit **Zlatograd**, a small ex-mining town 35 miles (55 km) southeast of Smolyan. This has a wonderful **Museum Quarter** where you can watch artisans at work, sip coffee in a 19th-century café, sample Rhodopean delights in a traditional *mehana*, and even stay – it offers atmospheric accommodations in period mansions.

**DAY THREE** Travel northwest past the well-developed ski resort of **Pamporovo** to **Shiroka Luka**, a delightful village of old stone houses tucked away in the mountains. Lunch at the excellent **Pri Slavchev** *mehana* before continuing west to the spectacular **Trigrad Gorge**, where you can visit the **Devil's Throat** cavern.

### Essentials

#### GETTING THERE

Fly to **Sofia Airport**, from which it's a five-hour bus journey to Smolyan.

#### WHERE TO STAY

**Trite Eli** (inexpensive) in Smolyan has spotless rooms and hiking information. +359 3018 1028  
**Pachilovska Kushta** (moderate) in the Museum Quarter at Zlatograd is bursting with period charm. [www.eac-zlatograd.com](http://www.eac-zlatograd.com)

**Arena di Serdica** (expensive) in Sofia offers five-star comforts. [www.arenadiserdica.com](http://www.arenadiserdica.com)

#### TOURIST INFORMATION

Smolyan: Mladeshki Dom; Zlatograd: [www.eac-zlatograd.com](http://www.eac-zlatograd.com)

### What Else to Eat

The scrumptious *banitsa* (pastry) known as **klin** is a Rhodopean staple that's cooked slowly on both sides, in much the same way as *patatnik*. The filling is made from rice, eggs, white cheese, and butter, and flavored with nettles or spinach. It's delicious served hot with a dollop of yogurt. Another favorite, **bob chorba**, is a thick, hearty soup that is popular throughout Bulgaria. It contains beans, peppers, tomatoes, celery, and carrots, flavored with mint or parsley. Traditionally prepared in a large earthenware pot, the Rhodopean version is made with white beans from Smolyan. For dessert, try **marudnik**, a kind of pancake with gently cooked wild berries. Buy some strawberry honey to take home.